

RUBY ELZY IN *PORGY AND BESS*

US soprano Elzy became famous for her role as Serena in Gershwin's *Porgy and Bess*. She is depicted in this painting of 1935 by artist Sergei Yurievich Sudeikin.

Broadway hits

His breakthrough came in 1919 with “Swanee,” a song recorded by the popular singer Al Jolson—it sold hundreds of thousands of copies. On the strength of this, he went on to collaborate with William Daly, a music director in the Broadway theaters, providing music for a string of hit shows. One of these, *Lady Be Good*—with the music by Gershwin and lyrics by Ira—marked the beginning of one of the world's great songwriting partnerships, which continued into the 1930s. Around this time, Gershwin began a lifelong love affair with the composer Kay Swift, but the couple never married.

Serious ambition

Despite his successes, Gershwin yearned to become known as a “serious” composer, first with his *Rhapsody in Blue*, a concert piece for piano and orchestra with jazz-inspired themes, and then with a full-blown Piano Concerto and the orchestral *An American in Paris*, a musical depiction of his trip to Paris in 1926. After the hit shows of the 1920s, he concentrated on more serious composition, and in particular the opera *Porgy and Bess*. It premiered in 1935, but was a commercial failure. Gershwin moved to Hollywood to work on the songs for the Astaire and Rogers film *Shall We Dance*.

In 1937, during an operation to remove a benign cyst from his brain, surgeons found a large malignant tumour. He died aged 39, hours after